

A Reader's Companion to *1929*

Andrew Ross Sorkin's *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History
and How It Shattered a Nation*

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for a [listener of the audiobook narration](#)

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Note on this document. This companion is a listening aid, not a substitute for the book. It was assembled entirely from publicly available secondary sources — publisher copy, book reviews, press interviews, and reader summaries — rather than from the text of *1929* itself, and every claim below is cited to one of those public sources in the References section. Because the goal is to help a listener keep names straight, character and institution sketches describe who people *were* and how they connect to one another; they deliberately omit how each person's individual story concludes. The chapter-by-chapter section is a conceptual reconstruction of the book's chronological arc, not a transcription of its actual chapter titles: reviewers note that Sorkin structures the book as a sequence of date-headed chapters (beginning February 1, 1929) grouped into two parts, rather than as topically titled chapters, and that precise chapter-by-chapter titles are not published online (Wikipedia contributors 2025; *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025). This document is not authorized, reviewed, or endorsed by the author or publisher.

Overview

1929 (Viking, 2025) is Andrew Ross Sorkin's narrative history of the Wall Street crash of 1929, its long buildup, and its aftermath through the New Deal-era banking reforms (Sorkin 2025; *1929 by Andrew Ross Sorkin* 2025; *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History – and How It Shattered a Nation* 2025). Sorkin, best known for his account of the 2008 financial crisis in *Too Big to Fail*, spent roughly eight years researching the book, drawing on archival material including previously unpublished Federal Reserve Bank of New York board records (Staff 2025; *Book Review: Andrew Ross Sorkin's "1929"* 2025). Rather than telling the crash as a story of charts and abstractions, the book is built around a cast of interlocking real people — bankers, speculators, regulators, and politicians — whose personal ambitions and rivalries shaped the boom, the crash, and the decade of reform that followed (*Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Shakespearean Characters Behind His New Book, "1929"* 2025; *'1929': Andrew Ross Sorkin looks at the worst crash in US history* 2025). Reviewers describe the book as unfolding in two parts: the first tracing the speculative boom from roughly February through October 1929, and the second following the crash's political and regulatory aftermath (*Sorkin's 1929: A Critique* 2025; *Sorkin's '1929': Panic, Politics, and the Search for Villains* 2025).

1 Cast of Characters

The figures below are the major, named individuals the book follows closely across its narrative, drawn from publisher and reviewer descriptions of the book’s principal cast (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025; *1929 by Andrew Ross Sorkin: Summary and Analysis* 2025; *Summary: 1929 by Andrew Ross Sorkin* 2025). Wilson and Coolidge, who appear only briefly as outgoing political context, are omitted at the reader’s request.

1.1 Charles E. Mitchell

Chairman of National City Bank (a predecessor of Citibank) and known as “Sunshine Charlie” for his relentless public optimism, Mitchell pioneered the mass marketing of stocks to ordinary Americans and used his bank’s resources to keep credit flowing to the market even when the Federal Reserve wanted to restrain it (*Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Shakespearean Characters Behind His New Book, “1929”* 2025; *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025). His running conflict with the Federal Reserve’s leadership is one of the book’s central threads connecting Wall Street to Washington.

1.2 Thomas W. Lamont

The senior partner at J.P. Morgan & Co. and the most influential private banker of the era, Lamont acted as an informal statesman for Wall Street, coordinating with fellow bankers and government officials to manage the market’s mood (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025; *Sorkin’s ‘1929’: Panic, Politics, and the Search for Villains* 2025). He is a connective figure between the House of Morgan, the New York Stock Exchange, and the Hoover administration.

1.3 J.P. Morgan Jr.

Head of the House of Morgan and heir to his father’s banking dynasty, Morgan represents the old-guard establishment of American finance, whose firm’s private influence over markets and government rivaled that of the Federal Reserve itself (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025). He works closely with Lamont throughout the book.

1.4 Richard Whitney

A vice president (and later president) of the New York Stock Exchange, Whitney became the public face of Wall Street’s efforts to project confidence on the trading floor during the market’s most volatile days, acting on behalf of the leading bankers’ consortium (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025; *‘1929’: Andrew Ross Sorkin looks at the worst crash in US history* 2025). He works in close coordination with Lamont and the Morgan-led banking group.

1.5 Jesse Livermore

A legendary independent stock trader famous for making and losing several fortunes, Livermore operated outside the banking establishment, trading on his own instincts about market psychology rather than on inside information or institutional loyalty (*Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Shakespearean Characters Behind His New Book, “1929”* 2025; *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025). He functions in the narrative as a skeptical outsider watching the same boom that bankers like Mitchell were fueling.

1.6 William C. Durant

The founder of General Motors, Durant reinvented himself in the late 1920s as one of Wall Street’s most aggressive stock market operators, organizing pools of investors to move prices in favored stocks (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*). His path connects General Motors, the speculative pool culture of the exchange, and fellow GM figure John J. Raskob.

1.7 John J. Raskob

A General Motors and DuPont executive who also chaired the Democratic National Committee, Raskob was a leading public evangelist for stock ownership, urging ordinary Americans that “everybody ought to be rich” through the market (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*; *Summary: 1929 by Andrew Ross Sorkin 2025*). He links the corporate world of General Motors to both Wall Street speculation and national politics.

1.8 Michael J. Meehan

A New York Stock Exchange specialist and stock promoter known for running trading pools in popular speculative stocks such as Radio Corporation of America (RCA), Meehan exemplifies the era’s loosely regulated market-manipulation practices (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*). His activities intersect with the same pool culture that drew in Durant and Raskob.

1.9 Herbert Hoover

Inaugurated president in March 1929, Hoover inherited a market boom he privately distrusted and then had to respond to its collapse, caught between his instincts for voluntary, business-led solutions and mounting pressure for federal action (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*; *‘1929’: Andrew Ross Sorkin looks at the worst crash in US history 2025*). His administration’s dealings with bankers like Lamont and Mitchell are a recurring axis of the book.

1.10 Andrew W. Mellon

A wealthy financier and industrialist serving as Treasury Secretary, Mellon represents the fusion of private fortune and public economic policy that characterized the era, shaping the government’s hands-off approach to the boom (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*). He works alongside Hoover through the crash’s early aftermath.

1.11 George L. Harrison

Governor of the Federal Reserve Bank of New York, Harrison inherited the internal Federal Reserve debates over whether and how to curb speculative lending, and dealt directly with bankers such as Mitchell whose actions the Fed was trying to restrain (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*). He is the book’s throughline for the Federal Reserve’s institutional perspective.

1.12 Franklin D. Roosevelt

Governor of New York during the crash and elected president in 1932, Roosevelt becomes central to the book’s second half as the political figure whose administration presided over the era’s regulatory response to Wall Street’s excesses (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History –*

Summary 2025; 1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History and How It Shattered a Nation 2025). He connects to Senator Carter Glass and investigator Ferdinand Pecora as reform-era figures.

1.13 Carter Glass

A U.S. Senator and former Treasury Secretary, Glass was a leading architect of banking reform legislation in the crash's aftermath, working to redraw the boundary between commercial and investment banking (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History and How It Shattered a Nation 2025*). His legislative efforts connect Washington's political response to the practices of bankers like Mitchell and Lamont profiled earlier in the book.

1.14 Ferdinand Pecora

Chief counsel to the U.S. Senate Committee on Banking and Currency, Pecora led the high-profile investigative hearings into Wall Street practices that followed the crash, questioning many of the book's banking figures directly about their conduct during the boom (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History and How It Shattered a Nation 2025; Sorkin's '1929': Panic, Politics, and the Search for Villains 2025*). His hearings serve as the narrative bridge between the crash and the reforms that followed it.

2 Cast of Institutions

2.1 National City Bank

A forerunner of Citibank and, under Charles Mitchell's leadership, one of the most aggressive commercial banks in extending credit for stock speculation and marketing securities directly to retail customers (*Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Shakespearean Characters Behind His New Book, "1929" 2025; 1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*). Its practices put it repeatedly at odds with the Federal Reserve.

2.2 J.P. Morgan & Co.

The most powerful private bank on Wall Street, led by Thomas Lamont and J.P. Morgan Jr., whose partners acted as informal coordinators of the banking community's response to market stress (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*). The firm's influence connects private finance directly to the New York Stock Exchange and to Washington.

2.3 New York Stock Exchange (NYSE)

The physical and symbolic center of American securities trading, where figures like Richard Whitney and Michael Meehan operated, and whose self-regulated trading floor practices are a recurring subject of the book (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*). It is the stage on which the boom's speculative excesses and the crash itself play out.

2.4 The Federal Reserve System

Comprising the Board in Washington and regional banks such as the Federal Reserve Bank of New York (led by George Harrison), the Fed grappled throughout the boom with whether and how to restrain speculative lending by banks like National City (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary 2025*). Its internal debates connect monetary policy to the conduct of

individual bankers profiled elsewhere in the book.

2.5 General Motors

The automaker at the center of two major characters' fortunes — founder William C. Durant and executive John J. Raskob — General Motors' stock was itself one of the era's most actively speculated-upon issues, tying industrial America directly to the market's mania (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025).

2.6 The White House and U.S. Treasury

The executive branch under Herbert Hoover and Treasury Secretary Andrew Mellon, and later under Franklin Roosevelt, whose evolving posture toward Wall Street — from voluntary cooperation to active regulation — structures the political half of the book's narrative (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025; *'1929': Andrew Ross Sorkin looks at the worst crash in US history* 2025).

2.7 U.S. Senate Committee on Banking and Currency

The congressional committee whose investigative hearings, led by chief counsel Ferdinand Pecora and shaped legislatively by Senator Carter Glass, became the public forum in which Wall Street's boom-era practices were examined and which produced the era's landmark banking reforms (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History and How It Shattered a Nation* 2025; *Sorkin's '1929': Panic, Politics, and the Search for Villains* 2025).

3 Chapter-by-Chapter Narrative Outline

As noted above, Sorkin structures the book as a long sequence of date-headed chapters within two parts rather than as titled, numbered chapters, and a complete public listing of those individual date-chapters was not found in the sources consulted (Wikipedia contributors 2025). The "chapters" below are instead a conceptual reconstruction of the book's narrative movements, grouped in the chronological order reviewers describe, to help a listener anticipate where the story is heading without revealing how any individual character's story resolves.

1. **The Boom in Full Swing (early 1929).** The book opens amid a roaring bull market. **Charles Mitchell** and **National City Bank** keep credit flowing to speculators even as the **Federal Reserve** grows uneasy, setting up the central tension between Wall Street's appetite and Washington's caution (*Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Shakespearean Characters Behind His New Book, "1929"* 2025; *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025).
2. **A New President Takes Office (March 1929).** **Herbert Hoover** is inaugurated into a market he privately mistrusts, while **Andrew Mellon** continues to shape a Treasury posture of minimal interference in the boom (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025; *'1929': Andrew Ross Sorkin looks at the worst crash in US history* 2025).
3. **The Machinery of Speculation (spring–summer 1929).** Pool operators such as **William C. Durant**, **John J. Raskob**, and **Michael J. Meehan** drive up favored stocks on the **New York Stock Exchange**, while **Thomas Lamont** and the House of **J.P. Morgan & Co.**

watch the market's temperature from above (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025).

4. **Cracks Beneath the Surface (late summer 1929).** As the market reaches its historic peak, independent skeptics like **Jesse Livermore** begin to sense the boom has outrun reality, even as public enthusiasm remains near its height (*Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Shakespearean Characters Behind His New Book, “1929”* 2025; *The 1929 Financial Thriller and the “We Can’t Help Ourselves” Theory of Financial Mania* 2025).
5. **The Tremors Begin (early–mid October 1929).** Confidence starts to waver on the exchange floor; **Richard Whitney** and the leading bankers grow increasingly attentive to signs of instability (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025).
6. **Black Thursday (October 24, 1929).** A wave of panic selling hits the **New York Stock Exchange**; **Thomas Lamont**, **J.P. Morgan Jr.**, and their fellow bankers organize a coordinated show of confidence on the floor, with **Richard Whitney** acting as their public face (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025; *‘1929’: Andrew Ross Sorkin looks at the worst crash in US history* 2025).
7. **A Fragile Reprieve (October 25–28, 1929).** A brief stabilization follows the bankers’ intervention, and the country debates whether the worst has passed (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025).
8. **Black Tuesday and Its Immediate Wake (October 29, 1929 onward).** Selling overwhelms the market again, and the scale of the losses becomes clear across Wall Street, testing every figure introduced so far, from **Charles Mitchell** to **Herbert Hoover** (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025; *‘1929’: Andrew Ross Sorkin looks at the worst crash in US history* 2025).
9. **Washington Tries to Steady the Country (late 1929–1930).** **Herbert Hoover** convenes business leaders and urges confidence, while the **Federal Reserve System** and figures like **George Harrison** weigh how aggressively to respond (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025).
10. **The Economy Contracts (1930–1931).** As economic conditions worsen and bank failures spread through the financial system, the limits of voluntary, business-led solutions become increasingly apparent (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025).
11. **A Nation in Crisis, A New Administration (1932–1933).** **Franklin D. Roosevelt** rises to national prominence and is elected president amid a deepening banking crisis, setting the stage for a fundamentally different relationship between Washington and Wall Street (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary* 2025; *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History and How It Shattered a Nation* 2025).
12. **The Reckoning (1933–1934).** **Ferdinand Pecora** leads the **U.S. Senate Committee on Banking and Currency’s** hearings, calling **Charles Mitchell**, **Richard Whitney**, and other figures from earlier in the book to account publicly for their conduct during the boom

(*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History and How It Shattered a Nation* 2025; *Sorkin's '1929': Panic, Politics, and the Search for Villains* 2025).

13. **Rebuilding the Rules (1933–1934).** **Carter Glass** and his congressional allies, working with the **Roosevelt** administration, translate the hearings' revelations into the era's landmark banking and securities reforms, reshaping the relationship between **National City Bank, J.P. Morgan & Co.**, and the institutions that regulate them (*1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History and How It Shattered a Nation* 2025).
14. **Looking Back.** The book closes by drawing a line from the 1929 crash and its reforms toward the financial crises of later decades, reflecting on what the era's central figures and institutions ultimately teach about market manias and their aftermath (Staff 2025; *Sorkin's '1929': Panic, Politics, and the Search for Villains* 2025).

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